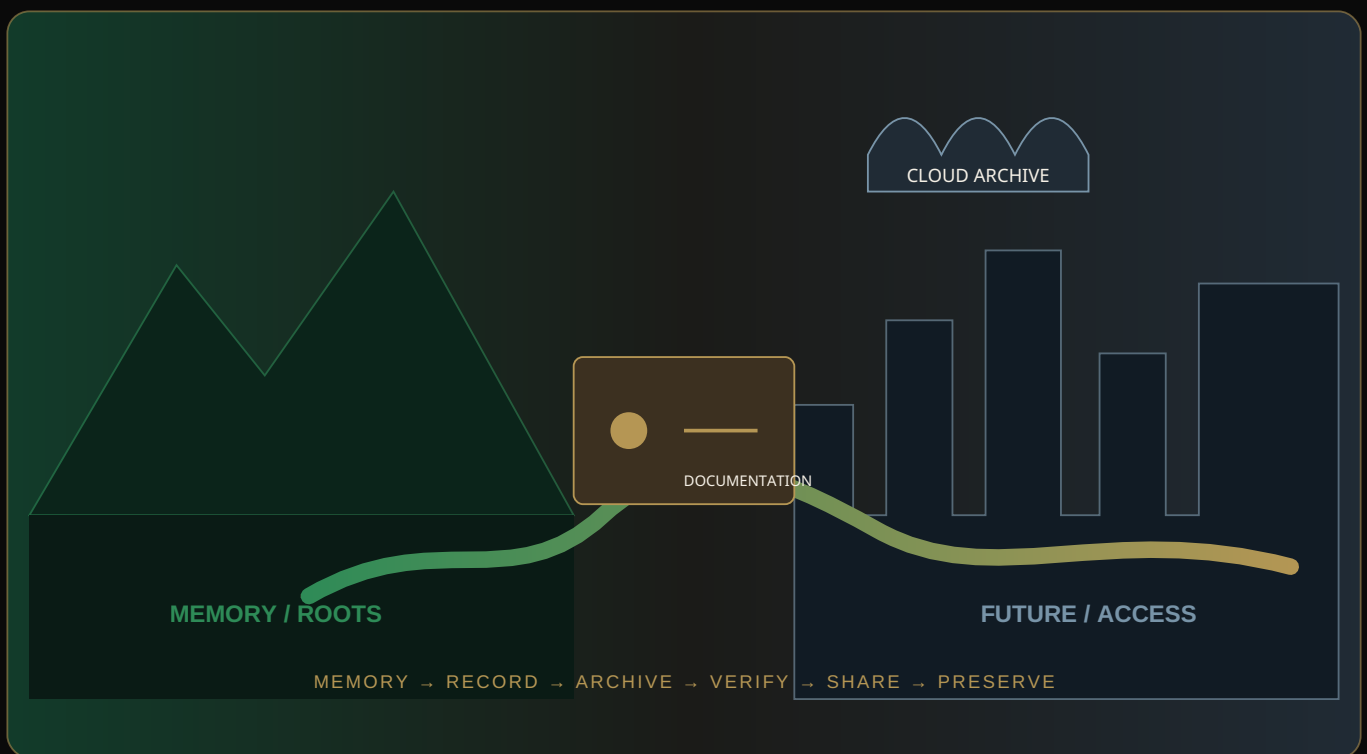


PRESERVING CULTURE IN A DIGITAL WORLD

“Memory becomes stronger when it is documented with care.”



Memory becomes stronger when it is documented with care. The digital world connects ancestral roots to future access.

“A culture can disappear without a single person deciding to erase it.

A story may simply stop being told. A word may no longer be taught. A photograph may lose the name of the people in it. A song may survive only in the memory of one person. A family recording may remain on a phone until the phone is lost. An old document may exist in a home but never be catalogued.

Digital technology changes this possibility. For the first time, families and

communities can record voices, photographs, documents, stories, music and memories at a scale that earlier generations could not easily achieve.

But technology alone cannot preserve culture. Preservation requires people who know what a record means, where it came from, who created it, and why it matters.

The goal is not simply to put Orakzai culture online. The goal is to make cultural memory discoverable, understandable, authentic, secure and available to future generations.”

WHAT DOES CULTURAL PRESERVATION MEAN?

Cultural preservation includes language, oral history, family photographs, letters, documents, genealogies, poetry, music, food knowledge, craft knowledge, stories, proverbs, festivals, religious history, architecture, landscape knowledge, traditional ecological knowledge, and community memories. However, not every item should be publicly published. Some knowledge may be private, sacred, family-specific, sensitive, restricted, or context-dependent.

PRESERVE ≠ PUBLISH EVERYTHING

Respect Privacy, Consent, and Sacredness

INTANGIBLE CULTURAL HERITAGE

Intangible cultural heritage (ICH) includes oral traditions, performing arts, social practices, rituals, festive events, knowledge concerning nature, and traditional craftsmanship. Connecting to Pages 59–70, it is vital to distinguish between documented culture and formally recognized UNESCO heritage. Not every Orakzai practice is formally recognized, but all are worth documenting.

ORAL HISTORY: THE METHOD OF MEMORY

Oral history records lived experience, language, personal memories, and community changes. As seen in Pages 64–66, it is a major method for capturing Orakzai history. However, oral history is evidence of memory, not automatically proof of fact. The strongest history comes from memory corroborated by other sources.

MEMORY + CORROBORATION

= STRONGER HISTORY

DIGITAL PRESERVATION WORKFLOW

Preservation is a process, not a single act. It begins with consent and ends with long-term stewardship. A responsible workflow ensures that records remain authentic and accessible.

CONSENT — RECORD — IDENTIFY — TRANSCRIBE — CONTEXT — STORE — BACKUP — PRESERVE

THE ETHICAL CORE: CONSENT

Consent is the foundation of ethical archiving. Before publishing, narrators must know who is collecting, why, and where it will appear. Recording does not grant an automatic right to publish.

METADATA: CONTEXT FOR MEMORY

A photograph or recording without metadata loses its historical value. Metadata provides the who, when, where, and why. It is the information that makes a digital file a historical record.

PHOTO + METADATA

= HISTORICAL RECORD

AI AND THE FUTURE OF HERITAGE

AI offers tools for transcription, translation, and discovery. However, it must never be used to manufacture history. AI-generated reconstructions are not evidence. Human review remains essential.

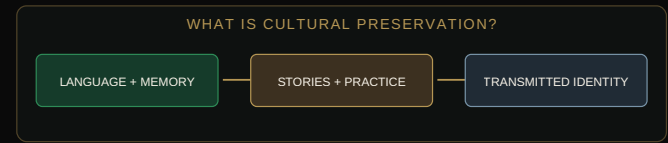
SOURCE → AI → HUMAN REVIEW

= RESPONSIBLE ARCHIVE

PRESERVATION PRIORITY MATRIX

Material	Urgency	Sensitivity	Priority
Oral histories (Elders)	HIGH	ASSESS INDIVIDUALLY	HIGH
Old photographs	HIGH	MEDIUM	HIGH
Manuscripts	HIGH	HIGH	HIGH
Family documents	MEDIUM	HIGH	MEDIUM
Music recordings	MEDIUM	MEDIUM	MEDIUM
Pashto vocabulary	HIGH	LOW	HIGH
Proverbs	MEDIUM	LOW	MEDIUM
Recipes	LOW	LOW	LOW
Migration stories	MEDIUM	MEDIUM	MEDIUM
Women's histories	HIGH	HIGH	HIGH

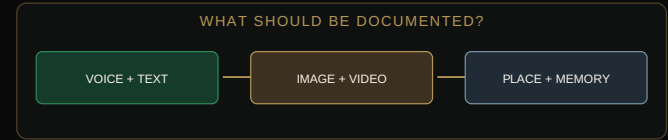
LOGIC ATLAS: DIGITAL PRESERVATION



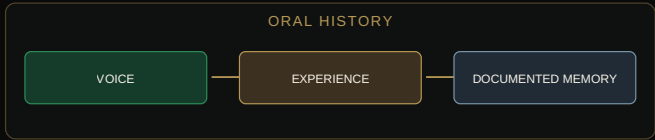
1. What is cultural preservation? — preservation framework.



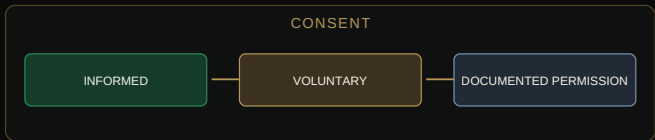
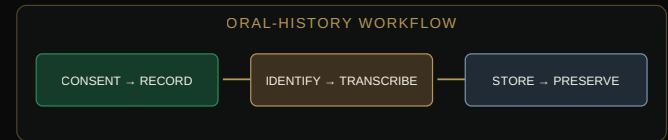
2. Intangible cultural heritage — preservation framework.



3. What should be documented? — preservation framework.

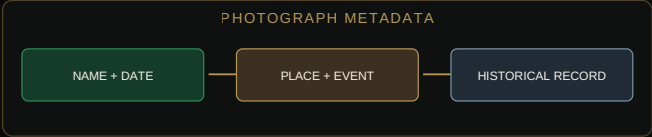


4. Oral history — preservation framework.



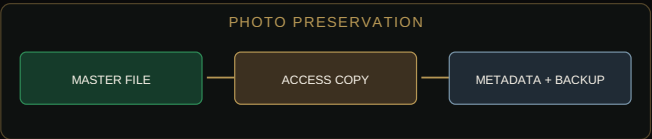
6. Consent — preservation framework.

5. Oral-history workflow — preservation framework.



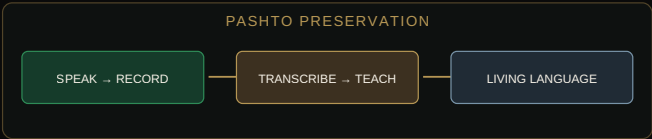
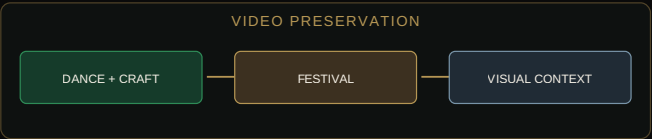
7. Family archive — preservation framework.

8. Photograph metadata — preservation framework.



9. Photo preservation — preservation framework.

10. Audio preservation — preservation framework.



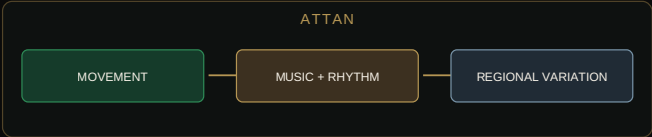
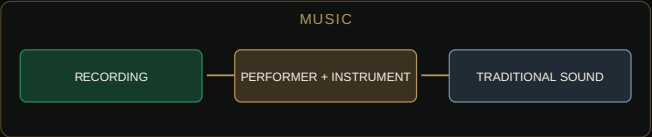
11. Video preservation — preservation framework.

12. Pashto preservation — preservation framework.



13. Local vocabulary — preservation framework.

14. Proverbs — preservation framework.



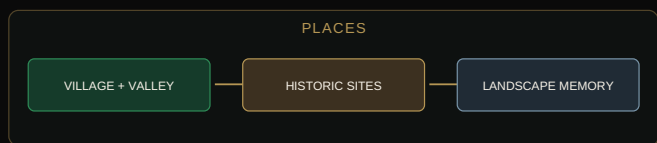
15. Music — preservation framework.

16. Attan — preservation framework.

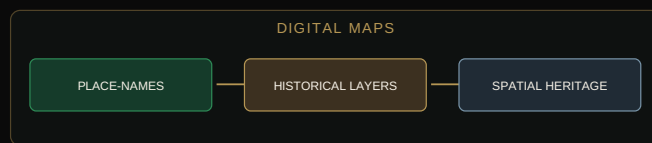


17. Food knowledge — preservation framework.

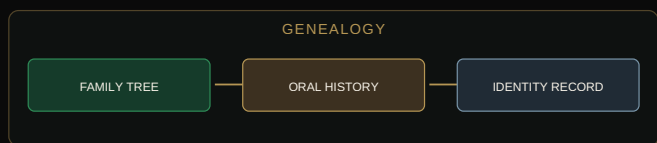
18. Crafts — preservation framework.



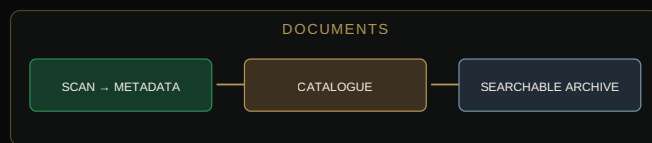
19. Places — preservation framework.



20. Digital maps — preservation framework.



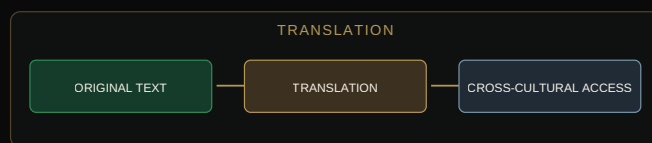
21. Genealogy — preservation framework.



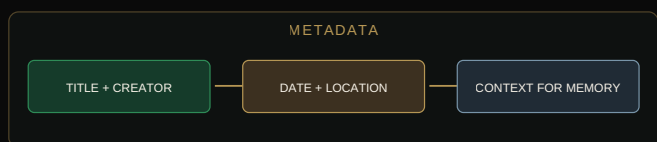
22. Documents — preservation framework.



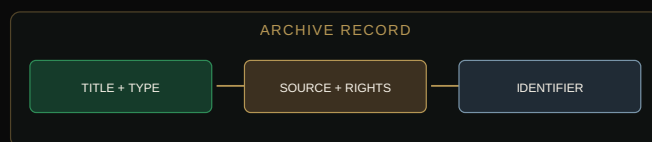
23. OCR — preservation framework.



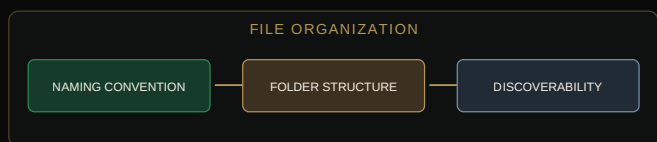
24. Translation — preservation framework.



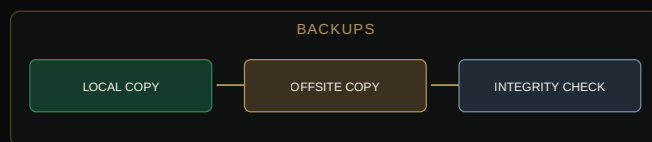
25. Metadata — preservation framework.



26. Archive record — preservation framework.



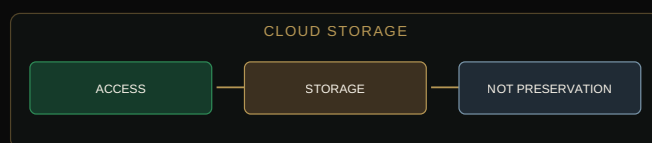
27. File organization — preservation framework.



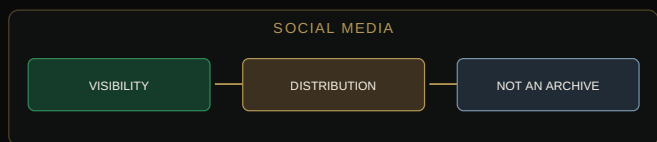
28. Backups — preservation framework.



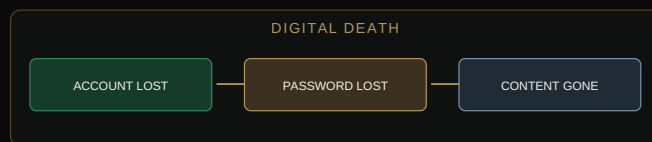
29. Checksums — preservation framework.



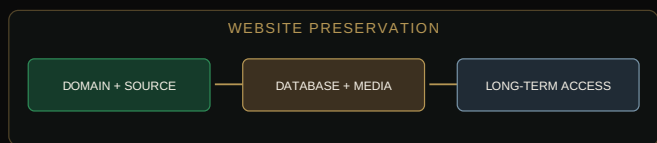
30. Cloud storage — preservation framework.



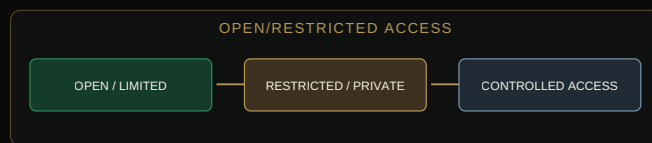
31. Social media — preservation framework.



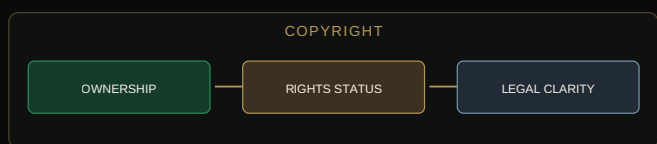
32. Digital death — preservation framework.



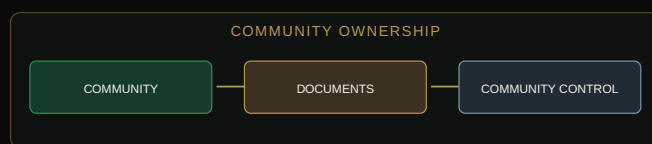
33. Website preservation — preservation framework.



34. Open/restricted access — preservation framework.



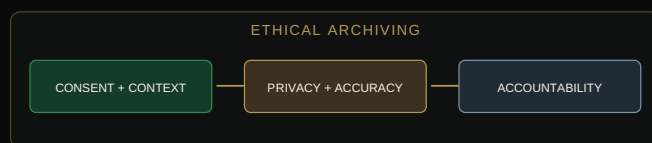
35. Copyright — preservation framework.



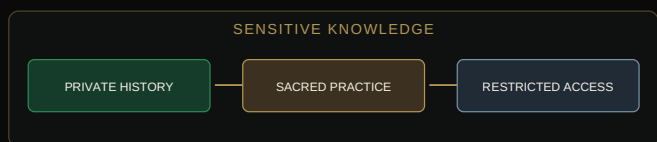
36. Community ownership — preservation framework.



37. Stakeholders — preservation framework.



38. Ethical archiving — preservation framework.



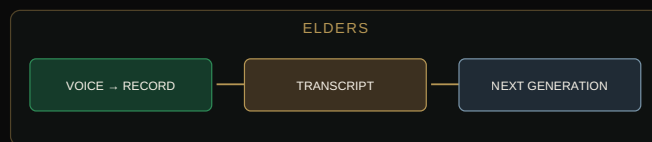
39. Sensitive knowledge — preservation framework.



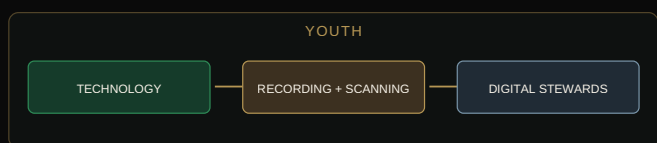
40. Children — preservation framework.



41. Women's histories — preservation framework.



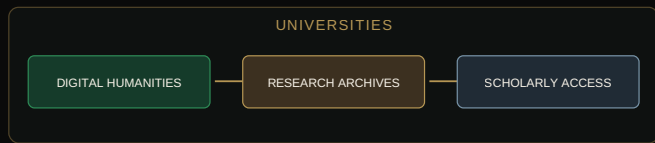
42. Elders — preservation framework.



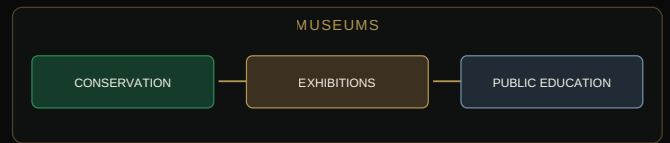
43. Youth — preservation framework.



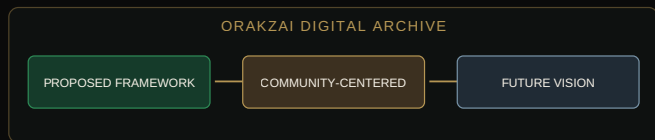
44. Schools — preservation framework.



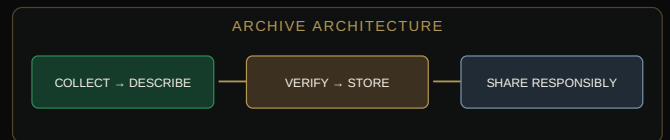
45. Universities — preservation framework.



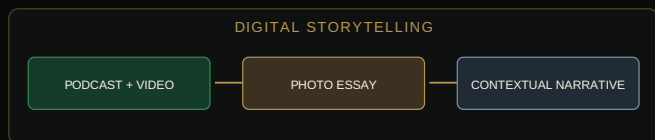
46. Museums — preservation framework.



47. Orakzai Digital Archive — preservation framework.



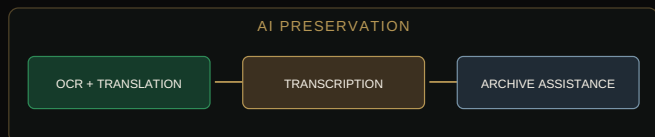
48. Archive architecture — preservation framework.



49. Digital storytelling — preservation framework.



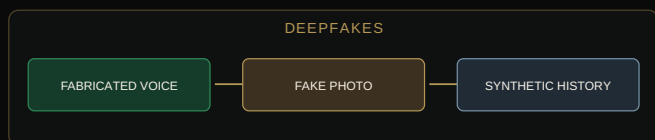
50. Social media risks — preservation framework.



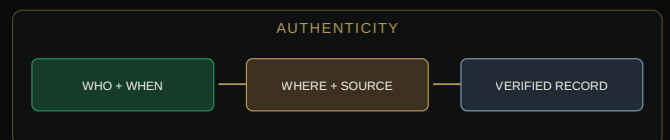
51. AI preservation — preservation framework.



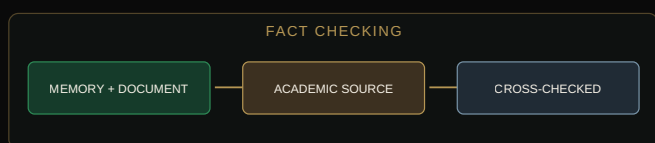
52. AI restoration — preservation framework.



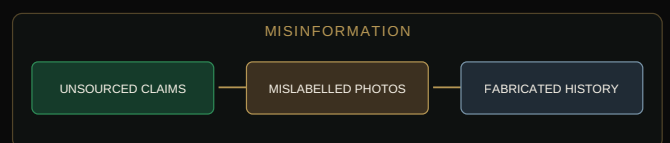
53. Deepfakes — preservation framework.



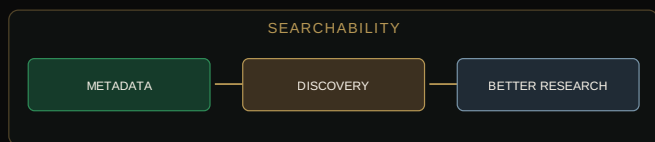
54. Authenticity — preservation framework.



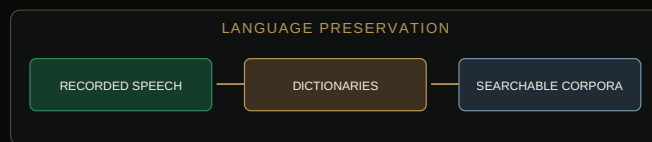
55. Fact checking — preservation framework.



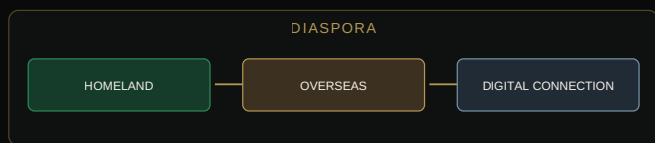
56. Misinformation — preservation framework.



57. Searchability — preservation framework.



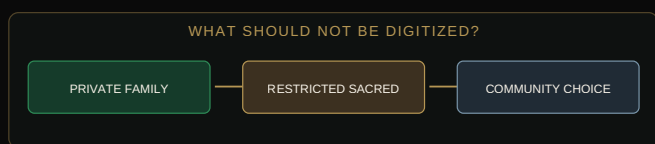
58. Language preservation — preservation framework.



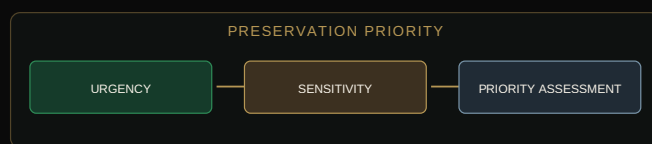
59. Diaspora — preservation framework.



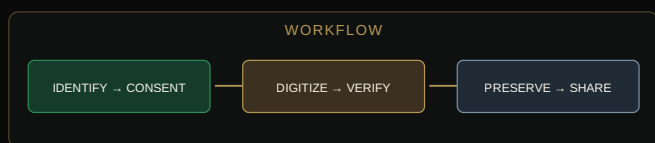
60. Future generations — preservation framework.



61. What should not be digitized? — preservation framework.



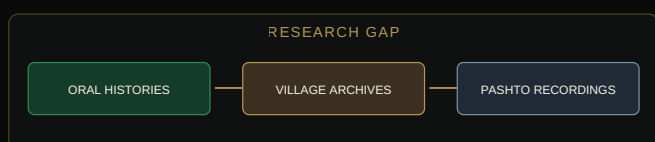
62. Preservation priority — preservation framework.



63. Workflow — preservation framework.



64. Five rules — preservation framework.



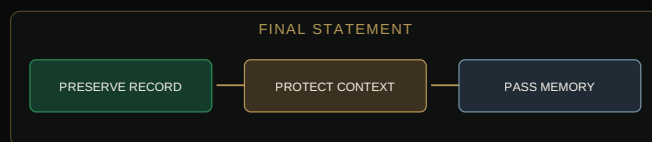
65. Research gap — preservation framework.



66. Oral-history questions — preservation framework.



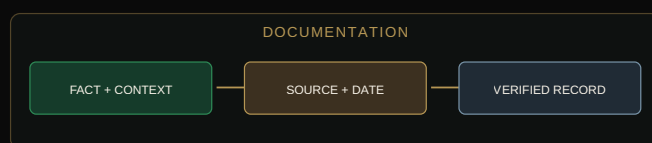
67. Author reflection — preservation framework.



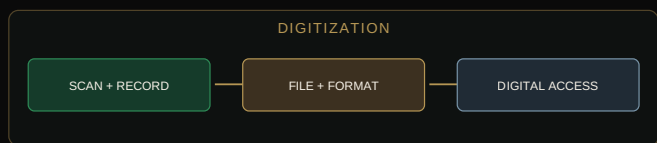
68. Final statement — preservation framework.



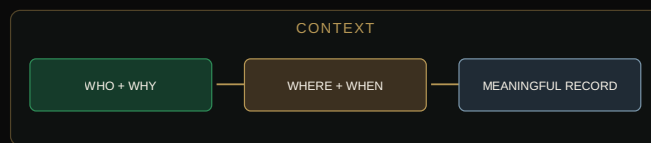
69. Memory — preservation framework.



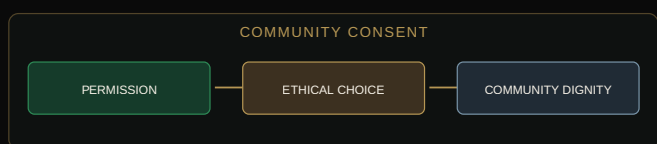
70. Documentation — preservation framework.



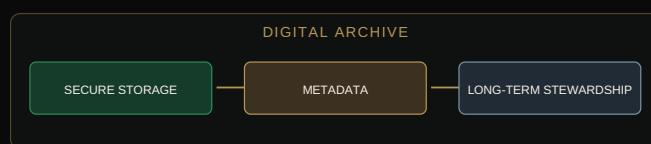
71. Digitization — preservation framework.



72. Context — preservation framework.



73. Community consent — preservation framework.



74. Digital archive — preservation framework.



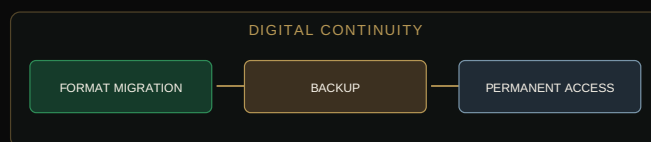
75. Cultural transmission — preservation framework.



76. Original vs restored — preservation framework.



77. Human review — preservation framework.



78. Digital continuity — preservation framework.



79. Future archive — preservation framework.



80. Digital legacy — preservation framework.

WHAT STILL NEEDS TO BE DOCUMENTED

- Orakzai oral histories
- Village-level archives
- Family photographs
- Pashto recordings
- Local vocabulary
- Proverbs and poetry
- Music and Attan
- Food and crafts

- Festivals and Hujras
- Women's oral histories
- Migration stories
- Historical manuscripts

“The largest archive may not be a building. It may be the memories stored in homes, phones, family boxes and human voices. The challenge is to preserve them before they become difficult to recover.”

ORAL HISTORY QUESTIONS

1. What family photographs should future generations see?
2. Who can identify the people in them?
3. What stories did your grandparents tell?
4. Which stories are no longer being told?
5. Which Pashto words are disappearing?
6. Which proverbs did elders use?
7. Which songs should be documented?
8. Which foods should be recorded?
9. Which crafts should be documented?
10. Which places carry important memories?
11. Which festivals should be documented?
12. What did the hujra mean to your generation?
13. What do elders remember that documents do not?
14. What experiences should remain private?
15. What should be shared publicly?
16. Who should control family archives?
17. How has migration changed cultural memory?
18. How has technology changed storytelling?
19. What should young people preserve?
20. What should future generations know about Orakzai life today?

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

“I have come to believe that preservation is not simply about saving old things. It is about saving meaning. A photograph matters because someone remembers the people in it. A recording matters because a voice carries more than words. A Pashto proverb matters because its meaning can travel across generations. A family story matters because it connects people who may never meet.

Technology gives us extraordinary tools. But the tools are not the memory. People are. The elder who remembers. The parent who keeps the photograph. The young person who scans the document. The researcher who checks the source. The community that decides what should remain private. And the next generation that chooses to listen.

If we use technology responsibly, the digital world does not have to replace cultural memory. It can become one of the places where that memory survives.”

PRESERVE THE RECORD. PROTECT THE CONTEXT. PASS THE MEMORY FORWARD.

RESEARCH SOURCES & FOOTNOTES

1. UNESCO, *Guidelines for the Preservation of Digital Heritage*, 2003.
2. UNESCO/PERSIST, *Guidelines for the Selection of Digital Heritage for Long-Term Preservation*, 2nd Ed, 2021.
3. Mehmood, N., et al., "Integrating Digital Tools for the Documentation and Revitalization of Minority Languages in Pakistan," *JELLE*, 2025.
4. Boyd, D., "Search, Explore, Connect: Disseminating Oral History in the Digital Age," *OHDA*, 2012.
5. Manan, S. A., et al., "Ecological planning towards language revitalization: The Torwali minority language in Pakistan," *IJAL*, 2021.
6. Rahman, T., "The role of digital archives in preserving Pashto," *KJLR*, 2020.